Designer vs Codex & Cursor

Comparative report | Generated 19 Oct 2026

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Projects TrafficSense, SkyFare, Brain Arena, JobPilot, PowerWise

Pros (7)

Pro	What Designer did	Compared with Codex / Cursor
Built the ML pipeline end to end TrafficSense	Designer generated a realistic 26k-row dataset, trained the Random Forest, added a fallback model and wired it to the FastAPI routes without extra prompts. Evidence	Codex needed separate prompts for data generation and training; in Cursor I had to run each script myself.
Wrote and passed its own API tests TrafficSense	11 API tests were written and run before the first deploy. Evidence	Cursor writes tests when asked but does not run them on its own.
Deployed with GitHub auto-deploy in one go SkyFare	Created the repo, pushed and linked Vercel so every push deploys. Evidence	Codex and Cursor stop at the code; deployment is left to me.
11 languages including RTL Arabic SkyFare	The whole UI, including the booking flow, works in 11 languages with right-to-left layout for Arabic.	Not compared yet
Playful mascot and sounds with no asset library Brain Arena	Brainy the SVG mascot has 6 moods, and all sounds are synthesized with the Web Audio API. Evidence	Both Codex and Cursor reached for icon or sound packages first.
Dependency-free PDF and DOCX resume parsing JobPilot	Resume text extraction works for both PDF and DOCX without adding a parsing library. Evidence	Cursor added pdf-parse and mammoth; Codex did the same.
Honest model accuracy vs a baseline PowerWise	Reported MAE 39 units and R2 0.93 on unseen homes against a baseline of MAE 132 / R2 0.28 instead of only showing the best number. Evidence	Codex reported training accuracy only.

Cons (5)

Con	What happened in Designer	How Codex / Cursor handle it
Python and Node setup needed retries TrafficSense	Installing the backend and frontend dependencies took several attempts before both servers ran.	Cursor uses my own terminal so setup issues show up immediately; Codex hits the same issue but reports it sooner.
Large generated data slowed the first build SkyFare	275k rows of simulated fares were bundled, which made the first production build slow.	Cursor suggested a smaller sample when asked; Codex produced a similar large file.
Needed manual GitHub App permission for Vercel Brain Arena	Auto-deploy only started after I gave the Vercel GitHub App access to the new repo.	Same limitation applies to any tool; Codex and Cursor do not attempt the deploy at all.
Very long single files JobPilot	Some pages ended up as one very long component, which made review harder.	Cursor tends to split components when it edits; Codex is similar to Designer.
Long thinking before the first file PowerWise	It planned for a long time before writing any code on the first prompt.	Cursor starts editing almost immediately.

11 items of 12 include a Codex / Cursor comparison. Comparisons are the tester's own observations.